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MaximillianGroup Employee Handbook

Pasadena, California

Effective Date: 2025

This handbook is intended to provide general information about MaximillianGroup’s policies and expectations. It is not a contract of employment and does not create any contractual rights. MaximillianGroup reserves the right to modify, revoke, suspend, terminate, or change any or all policies at any time, with or without notice. California law governs all employment matters described herein.

Before Distribution — Items Requiring Customization: The following items in this handbook must be filled in before distributing to employees: - **Section 6.1** — Select the pay period schedule (bi-weekly or semi-monthly). - **Section 6.2** — Set the prior-approval threshold dollar amount for expense reimbursements. - Remove this notice once all items are finalized and the handbook has been reviewed by a California employment attorney.

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1. Welcome & Company Overview

1.1 Welcome Message

Welcome to MaximillianGroup.

We are a lean, creative, and client-focused firm built on the belief that great ideas — executed with precision and integrity — move businesses forward. Whether you are a new team member, a long-term collaborator, or a contractor joining us for a specific engagement, we are glad you are here.

Our Mission

MaximillianGroup exists to help clients grow through smart advertising, strategic marketing, meaningful business development, and innovative program development. We do this by bringing together talented people who care deeply about their craft and about the clients they serve.

Our Creative and Professional Standards

We hold ourselves to a high standard — not just in the quality of our work product, but in how we conduct ourselves professionally. We believe that creativity and professionalism are not opposites; the best work is both inspired and disciplined.

Our Client Service Philosophy

Every client deserves our full attention, honest counsel, and best effort. We do not treat clients as transactions. We treat them as partners. We communicate clearly, deliver on our commitments, and take responsibility when things do not go as planned.

1.2 About MaximillianGroup

MaximillianGroup is a California-based advertising, marketing, and business development firm headquartered in Pasadena, California. We provide services including:

- **Advertising & Marketing Services** — Campaign strategy, brand development, content creation, media planning, and creative execution for clients across industries.
- **Program Development** — Design and management of structured programs that help clients achieve defined business outcomes.
- **Business Development Consulting** — Strategic guidance to help clients identify, pursue, and secure new business opportunities.

Our Culture

We operate as a small, collaborative team. Most of our work is performed remotely or in hybrid arrangements, with client meetings, collaborative sessions, and project work conducted in-person or virtually as needed. We value autonomy, accountability, clear communication, and a shared commitment to excellent outcomes.

Our size is a feature, not a limitation. We are nimble, personal, and deeply invested in the success of each engagement.

1.3 Handbook Purpose

This handbook describes MaximillianGroup's general policies, expectations, and practices. It applies to all employees and, where applicable, is provided to contractors for reference regarding conduct expectations during engagements with MaximillianGroup clients and staff.

This handbook is not a contract. Nothing in this handbook creates or is intended to create a promise or representation of continued employment. Employment at MaximillianGroup is at-will, as described in Section 2.1.

Subject to Change. MaximillianGroup may update this handbook at any time. The most current version supersedes all prior versions. Employees will be notified of material changes.

California Law Controls. Where this handbook addresses legal requirements, it is written to comply with California law. California law may provide greater rights or protections than federal law in many areas. This handbook is educational only and is not legal advice.

1.4 Equal Employment Opportunity (EEO)

MaximillianGroup is an equal opportunity employer. We are committed to providing a workplace free from discrimination, harassment, and retaliation.

No Discrimination. MaximillianGroup does not discriminate in hiring, promotion, compensation, discipline, termination, or any other term or condition of employment on the basis of any characteristic protected by California or federal law.

Protected Categories under California Law include:

- Race, color, ancestry, national origin, and ethnic group identification
- Religion and religious creed
- Age (40 and over)
- Disability (physical or mental)
- Sex (including pregnancy, childbirth, breastfeeding, and related medical conditions)
- Gender, gender identity, and gender expression
- Sexual orientation
- Marital status
- Medical condition
- Military and veteran status
- Genetic information
- Political affiliation or activities
- Any other characteristic protected by the California Fair Employment and Housing Act (FEHA) or other applicable law

Reasonable Accommodations. MaximillianGroup will provide reasonable accommodations to qualified individuals with disabilities, for sincerely held religious beliefs, and for pregnancy-related conditions, unless

doing so would impose an undue hardship. Employees or applicants requesting an accommodation should contact the company principal directly.

Anti-Retaliation. MaximillianGroup prohibits retaliation against any individual who, in good faith, makes a complaint about discrimination or harassment, participates in an investigation, or exercises any right protected by law. Retaliation is itself a serious violation of this policy and may result in disciplinary action up to and including termination.

2. Employment Relationship

2.1 At-Will Employment

Employment at MaximillianGroup is at-will. This means that either the employee or MaximillianGroup may end the employment relationship at any time, for any reason that is not prohibited by law, with or without notice.

Nothing in this handbook, any offer letter, or any verbal or written communication from any MaximillianGroup representative creates a contract of employment for any specific period of time or changes the at-will nature of employment, unless a written employment contract signed by both parties expressly states otherwise.

This at-will policy may not be modified by any supervisor, manager, or representative of MaximillianGroup unless such modification is in writing and signed by the company principal.

2.2 Employee Classifications

MaximillianGroup classifies its workers as follows to ensure compliance with applicable wage and hour laws:

Exempt Employees

Exempt employees are salaried employees who meet the legal tests for exemption from California's overtime and meal/rest break laws under the executive, administrative, professional, or other applicable exemption. Exempt employees are expected to work the hours necessary to fulfill their responsibilities.

Non-Exempt Employees

Non-exempt employees are entitled to all California wage and hour protections, including overtime pay, meal breaks, rest breaks, and accurate timekeeping. Non-exempt employees must accurately record all hours worked.

Part-Time Employees

Part-time employees are those regularly scheduled to work fewer than 40 hours per week. Part-time employees may be exempt or non-exempt depending on their role and compensation.

Temporary Employees

Temporary employees are hired for a defined period or project. Temporary employment ends when the project or period concludes. Temporary employees do not receive ongoing benefits unless specifically provided in their offer.

Seasonal Employees

Seasonal employees are hired for recurring but time-limited periods tied to business cycles or seasonal demand.

Classification as exempt or non-exempt is determined by California law, not by job title or the preferences of either party.

2.3 Independent Contractors

MaximillianGroup works with independent contractors on a regular basis. This section applies to anyone engaged by MaximillianGroup as an independent contractor.

Contractors Are Not Employees. Independent contractors are not employees of MaximillianGroup. They are not entitled to employee benefits, workers' compensation coverage (unless separately arranged), unemployment insurance, or other employment-related protections unless required by law.

Separate Contractor Agreements Required. All independent contractor engagements must be governed by a written Independent Contractor Agreement signed by both parties prior to the commencement of any work. No independent contractor engagement is authorized without an executed agreement.

California AB 5 and Borello Standards. California applies a strict legal test — the “ABC test” under AB 5 (Labor Code § 2750.3 et seq.) — to determine whether a worker is an employee or an independent contractor for most purposes. MaximillianGroup takes worker classification seriously and is committed to lawful classification. Workers who believe they have been misclassified should raise the concern immediately.

For occupations potentially exempt from AB 5, the Borello multi-factor test may apply. Contractor classification will be reviewed with legal counsel as appropriate.

Taxes and Insurance. Independent contractors are responsible for their own federal and state income taxes, self-employment taxes, and any required business insurance, unless otherwise specified in the contractor agreement.

No Implied Employment. Contractors should not represent themselves as employees of MaximillianGroup without express authorization. Contractors must not sign contracts, make commitments, or incur obligations on behalf of MaximillianGroup without authorization.

2.4 Introductory Period

New employees may be subject to an introductory period of up to 90 days from their date of hire. The introductory period is not a guarantee of employment for any specific period; employment remains at-will throughout and after the introductory period.

During the introductory period, new employees and the company have the opportunity to assess fit, performance expectations, and role alignment. Feedback will be provided and expected. Completion of the introductory period does not alter the at-will employment relationship.

3. Hiring & Onboarding

3.1 Employment Eligibility

All new employees must provide documentation establishing their identity and authorization to work in the United States. MaximillianGroup complies with the requirements of the Immigration Reform and Control Act (IRCA) and completes Form I-9 for every new hire.

Employees must provide required documentation within three business days of their start date. Employment is contingent upon successful completion of the I-9 process.

If MaximillianGroup uses E-Verify, employees will be notified as part of the onboarding process.

3.2 Background Checks

MaximillianGroup may conduct background checks as part of its hiring process. All background checks will be conducted in compliance with California law, including the Investigative Consumer Reporting Agencies Act (ICRAA) and applicable fair chance employment laws.

Candidates will receive required written disclosures and will be asked to provide written authorization before any background check is initiated. Any adverse action based on background check results will follow the procedures required by law, including providing a copy of the report and opportunity to respond.

MaximillianGroup complies with California's "ban the box" rules and does not inquire about criminal history until a conditional offer of employment has been made, where required by law.

3.3 Confidentiality & Intellectual Property Agreements

Due to the nature of MaximillianGroup's work — including access to client strategies, campaign materials, creative assets, proprietary methodologies, and confidential business information — all employees are required to sign a Confidentiality and Intellectual Property Agreement as a condition of employment.

This agreement covers:

- Protection of client confidential information
- Ownership of work product created during employment
- Non-disclosure obligations during and after employment
- Use and disclosure of proprietary tools, processes, and systems

The specific terms are set forth in the agreement itself. Employees should review this agreement carefully before signing. Questions should be directed to the company principal.

3.4 Employee Records

MaximillianGroup maintains employee records as required by law and as necessary to administer employment.

Keeping Records Current. Employees are responsible for notifying MaximillianGroup promptly of any changes to their contact information, emergency contacts, tax withholding status, or other personal information relevant to employment.

Privacy. Employee records are maintained confidentially. Access is limited to those with a legitimate need. Employees have rights to inspect their personnel files as provided by California Labor Code § 1198.5.

Retention. Records are retained in accordance with applicable legal requirements.

4. Workplace Conduct

4.1 Professional Conduct

MaximillianGroup expects all employees and contractors to conduct themselves professionally in all work-related contexts — whether at the office, at a client site, at an industry event, or in a remote/virtual environment.

Core Expectations:

- Treat colleagues, clients, vendors, and all others with courtesy and respect
- Communicate clearly, honestly, and constructively
- Meet commitments and communicate proactively when circumstances change
- Represent MaximillianGroup with integrity at all times
- Protect client and company confidential information
- Avoid conflicts of interest or situations that could create the appearance of a conflict
- Exercise sound judgment in all professional decisions

We do not impose a rigid corporate formality, but we do expect maturity, reliability, and good faith in every professional interaction.

4.2 Anti-Harassment & Anti-Discrimination

Policy Statement

MaximillianGroup is committed to maintaining a workplace free from unlawful harassment, discrimination, and retaliation. This policy applies to all employees, contractors, vendors, and clients in all work-related contexts.

Prohibited Conduct

Harassment is unwelcome conduct based on a protected characteristic that creates a hostile, intimidating, or offensive work environment, or that results in an adverse employment decision. Harassment may be verbal, written, physical, visual, or electronic. Examples include, but are not limited to:

- Offensive jokes, slurs, epithets, or name-calling
- Threats, intimidation, or coercion
- Unwelcome physical contact
- Displaying or circulating offensive materials
- Sexual advances, requests for sexual favors, or other verbal or physical conduct of a sexual nature (sexual harassment)

- Interference with work performance based on a protected characteristic

California FEHA Rights

Employees have rights under the California Fair Employment and Housing Act (FEHA) to a workplace free from discrimination and harassment. FEHA covers employers with five or more employees for most harassment claims and two or more employees for sexual harassment. MaximillianGroup complies with FEHA regardless of its current employee count.

Reporting Procedures

Any employee who believes they have experienced or witnessed harassment, discrimination, or retaliation should report it immediately to the company principal. Reports may be made verbally or in writing.

If the company principal is the subject of the complaint, or if the employee is uncomfortable reporting to the company principal, the employee may report directly to MaximillianGroup's legal counsel, or file a complaint directly with:

- **California Civil Rights Department (CRD):** 1-800-884-1684 | <https://civildrights.ca.gov>
- **U.S. Equal Employment Opportunity Commission (EEOC):** 1-800-669-4000 | <https://www.eeoc.gov>

Investigation

MaximillianGroup will promptly and thoroughly investigate all complaints. Investigations will be conducted impartially and with appropriate confidentiality. Both parties will have an opportunity to present information.

No Retaliation

MaximillianGroup strictly prohibits retaliation against anyone who reports harassment or discrimination in good faith, participates in an investigation, or exercises any legal right. Retaliation is independently subject to disciplinary action.

Supervisor Obligations

Anyone in a supervisory role at MaximillianGroup is required to:

- Model appropriate professional conduct
- Report any harassment or discrimination they observe or become aware of, even if no formal complaint is made
- Never condition any employment benefit on an employee's submission to or rejection of unwelcome conduct
- Cooperate fully in any investigation

4.3 Complaint Reporting Procedure

Employees who have a work-related concern, complaint, or grievance — including but not limited to concerns about harassment, discrimination, wage and hour compliance, safety, or other policy violations — are encouraged to raise the issue promptly.

How to Report:

1. Speak directly with the company principal.
2. Submit a written complaint to the company principal by email or the Employee Complaint Form (see Section 12).

3. If the concern involves the company principal, or if the employee is uncomfortable with direct reporting, the employee may contact legal counsel or the applicable government agency.

Response Process:

MaximillianGroup will acknowledge receipt of the complaint, conduct an investigation appropriate to the nature of the complaint, and communicate findings and any resulting action to the extent permissible and appropriate. The timeframe for resolution will depend on the complexity of the matter.

4.4 Workplace Violence Prevention Plan

MaximillianGroup is committed to providing a safe work environment free from violence, threats of violence, and intimidation. Consistent with California Labor Code § 6401.9 (effective July 1, 2024), MaximillianGroup maintains a Workplace Violence Prevention Plan (WVPP).

Prohibited Conduct

The following are strictly prohibited:

- Any act of physical violence, threats of violence, or intimidation in the workplace or in connection with work
- Possession of weapons (see Section 4.6)
- Conduct that a reasonable person would perceive as a threat of harm

Reporting

Employees who witness or experience workplace violence or threats should:

1. If there is an immediate threat, call 911 immediately.
2. Report the incident to the company principal as soon as it is safe to do so.
3. Document the incident in writing.

MaximillianGroup will investigate all reports of workplace violence and will take appropriate corrective action.

Violent Incident Log

MaximillianGroup maintains a violent incident log as required by California law, recording workplace violence incidents. This log is maintained in accordance with applicable privacy requirements.

4.5 Drug & Alcohol Policy

MaximillianGroup maintains a drug and alcohol-free workplace.

Prohibited Conduct:

- Reporting to work under the influence of alcohol or any impairing substance
- Consuming alcohol or impairing substances during work hours or at work-related functions where such consumption would affect work performance or professional conduct
- Possessing, distributing, or selling illegal drugs in the workplace or in connection with work

Prescription Medications. Employees taking legally prescribed medications that may affect their ability to safely perform their job duties should notify the company principal so that appropriate accommodations can be considered.

Cannabis. Notwithstanding California’s legalization of adult-use cannabis, employees may not be impaired by cannabis during work hours. MaximillianGroup complies with California law regarding cannabis testing and off-duty cannabis use.

Testing. MaximillianGroup reserves the right to conduct drug and alcohol testing consistent with California law, including where there is reasonable suspicion of impairment.

4.6 Weapons Policy

Possession or carrying of any weapon — including but not limited to firearms, knives with blades over certain lengths, and other dangerous instruments — is prohibited on MaximillianGroup premises, at client sites visited on behalf of MaximillianGroup, and at company-sponsored events, except where expressly authorized by applicable law (such as licensed law enforcement officers required by law to carry).

4.7 Workplace Bullying / Respectful Workplace

MaximillianGroup is committed to a respectful workplace. Bullying — defined as repeated, unreasonable conduct directed at an employee or group of employees that creates a risk to health and safety — is not tolerated.

Bullying behavior may include:

- Persistent unwarranted criticism
- Exclusion or social isolation
- Undermining work performance through withholding information, setting impossible deadlines, or sabotage
- Humiliating or ridiculing a person publicly

Bullying should be reported using the procedures in Section 4.3. While California does not currently have a stand-alone workplace bullying law, conduct that amounts to harassment based on a protected characteristic is covered by FEHA and will be treated accordingly.

4.8 Dress Code & Appearance

MaximillianGroup operates primarily in creative and professional services environments. We expect employees to dress and present themselves in a manner appropriate to their work context.

General Standard — Creative Professional

Our baseline is “creative professional” — polished, intentional, and appropriate for a client-facing services firm. We do not prescribe a rigid uniform, but we expect employees to exercise good judgment.

Client-Facing Standards

When meeting with clients in person, employees should dress to reflect the professional nature of the engagement. When in doubt, err on the side of more formal attire and ask in advance if there are specific expectations.

Remote Meeting Expectations

When participating in video calls with clients, partners, or external parties:

- Dress professionally on the visible portions of your appearance
- Ensure your background is clean and presentable (or use a professional virtual background)
- Good lighting and audio quality are part of your professional presentation

Tattoos, Piercings, and Personal Expression

We respect individual expression and do not have blanket restrictions on tattoos or piercings. Use judgment about the context and the client relationship.

5. Attendance, Scheduling & Remote Work

5.1 Work Schedules

MaximillianGroup does not maintain a single standard work schedule. Work schedules are established based on role, client needs, and individual arrangements. Non-exempt employees will have a defined schedule that is communicated at or before the start of employment.

Employees are expected to be available and responsive during agreed working hours and to communicate promptly about any changes to their availability.

5.2 Timekeeping

Non-Exempt Employees. All non-exempt employees are required to accurately record all time worked, including start and end times and all meal and rest break periods. Time records must be submitted in accordance with MaximillianGroup's payroll practices.

Falsification of time records is a serious violation of company policy and may result in disciplinary action, up to and including termination.

Exempt Employees. Exempt employees are not required to track hours worked in the same manner, but may be asked to track time for project management or client billing purposes.

5.3 Meal & Rest Breaks

MaximillianGroup complies with California's mandatory meal and rest break requirements.

Meal Breaks:

- Non-exempt employees working more than 5 hours in a workday are entitled to an unpaid, uninterrupted meal period of at least 30 minutes before the end of the 5th hour of work.

- If an employee works more than 10 hours in a workday, a second meal period of at least 30 minutes is required before the end of the 10th hour.
- A first meal period may be waived by mutual written consent if the total hours worked is no more than 6 hours. A second meal period may be waived if the total hours worked is no more than 12 hours and the first meal period was not waived.

Rest Breaks:

- Non-exempt employees are entitled to a paid, uninterrupted rest break of at least 10 minutes for every 4 hours worked (or major fraction thereof).
- Rest breaks cannot be combined with meal breaks or taken at the beginning or end of a shift.

Premium Pay. If MaximillianGroup fails to provide a required meal or rest break, the employee is entitled to one additional hour of pay at the regular rate of compensation for each missed break, per California Labor Code § 226.7.

5.4 Overtime

MaximillianGroup complies with California's overtime laws, which are more generous than federal law.

Daily Overtime:

- Non-exempt employees are entitled to overtime pay at 1.5x their regular rate for hours worked over 8 in a single workday and for the first 8 hours worked on the 7th consecutive day in a workweek.
- Double time (2x regular rate) is required for hours worked over 12 in a single workday and for all hours over 8 on the 7th consecutive workday in a workweek.

Weekly Overtime:

- Non-exempt employees are entitled to overtime at 1.5x for hours worked over 40 in a workweek (in addition to daily overtime, whichever provides greater pay).

Authorization. Non-exempt employees should obtain advance approval before working overtime. Unauthorized overtime will be paid as required by law, but may be subject to disciplinary action.

5.5 Attendance Expectations

Regular attendance and punctuality are essential to fulfilling professional obligations and client commitments.

Employees are expected to:

- Be present and ready to work at their scheduled start time
- Provide advance notice to the company principal of any expected absence or tardiness as soon as practicable
- Notify the company principal promptly if unexpected absence or tardiness arises
- Keep absences and tardiness to a minimum

Excessive or patterned absenteeism, tardiness, or failure to give notice may result in disciplinary action.

5.6 Remote Work Policy

MaximillianGroup supports remote and hybrid work arrangements. Many employees perform all or most of their work remotely.

Home Office Expectations

Employees working remotely are responsible for maintaining a work environment that allows them to perform their duties effectively and professionally. This includes:

- A dedicated workspace that is reasonably free from distractions during working hours
- A reliable internet connection with adequate speed for video conferencing and file transfer
- Proper physical security for company and client materials and equipment

Confidentiality

Remote employees must take all reasonable steps to protect confidential company and client information. This includes:

- Not conducting confidential conversations in public or semi-public spaces
- Ensuring computer screens are not visible to unauthorized persons
- Securing physical documents
- Locking devices when not in use

Internet and Security Requirements

- Use company-approved security software, including VPN and antivirus tools as directed
- Do not conduct company work on public or unsecured Wi-Fi without a VPN
- Follow password management best practices; do not share credentials
- Report any security incidents, suspected breaches, or lost/stolen devices immediately

Equipment Usage

Company-provided equipment is for business use. Limited personal use that does not interfere with work performance is generally acceptable, but employees should have no expectation of privacy in their use of company equipment or systems.

Personal devices used for company work must comply with the same security requirements as company-owned devices.

Zoom / Virtual Meeting Professionalism

When participating in client-facing virtual meetings:

- Use a professional background or a clean, uncluttered physical setting
- Mute your microphone when not speaking
- Dress professionally for video-enabled sessions
- Test audio and video in advance of important meetings
- Be on time; pre-join a few minutes early for high-stakes calls

5.7 Travel & Client Meetings

Business Travel

Travel required by MaximillianGroup for business purposes will be reimbursed in accordance with Section 6.2 (Expense Reimbursement). Employees should obtain prior approval for business travel and should use reasonably economical options.

Client Meetings

Employees attending client meetings, whether in person or virtual, represent MaximillianGroup and are expected to be prepared, professional, and punctual. Any materials shared with clients should be reviewed and approved through MaximillianGroup's standard review process before use.

Mileage

Employees required to use their personal vehicle for business purposes will be reimbursed at the then-current IRS standard mileage rate (or as otherwise required by California law). Commuting mileage is not reimbursable.

6. Compensation & Payroll

6.1 Payroll Practices

Pay Periods

MaximillianGroup pays employees on a [bi-weekly / semi-monthly] basis. Specific pay dates will be communicated at onboarding. California requires that wages be paid at least twice per month.

Direct Deposit

MaximillianGroup strongly encourages direct deposit. Employees will be provided with direct deposit enrollment information at onboarding. Paychecks include an itemized wage statement as required by California Labor Code § 226.

Deductions

Deductions from employee paychecks are limited to those authorized by law or by the employee in writing. Employees have the right to an itemized statement of earnings and deductions with each payment.

6.2 Expense Reimbursement

MaximillianGroup reimburses employees for all necessary and reasonable expenses incurred in the course of performing their job duties, consistent with California Labor Code § 2802.

Covered Expenses May Include:

- Business mileage (personal vehicle use required for work, excluding commuting)
- Business travel (airfare, lodging, ground transportation for approved trips)
- Business meals (with clients or colleagues, with prior approval)
- Phone and internet (a reasonable portion of monthly costs attributable to work use)
- Software subscriptions and tools required to perform job duties
- Client-related out-of-pocket expenses authorized in advance

Process:

- All expenses must be submitted within 30 days of being incurred, along with appropriate receipts
- Expenses over \$[defined threshold] require prior approval
- Expense reimbursement requests should be submitted using the Expense Reimbursement Form (see Section 12)

Note: Under California Labor Code § 2802, the company may not require employees to bear the cost of business expenses. Employees who believe they are incurring unreimbursed work-related expenses should raise the issue with the company principal promptly.

6.3 Performance Reviews

MaximillianGroup may conduct periodic performance reviews to provide feedback and discuss professional development. The frequency and format of reviews are at the discretion of the company principal.

Performance reviews are not a guarantee of continued employment or compensation increases. Compensation adjustments, if any, are at the discretion of the company and subject to the available budget.

6.4 Bonuses & Incentives

MaximillianGroup may offer discretionary bonuses or incentive payments. Any bonus that has not been guaranteed in writing in advance is discretionary, and the company retains the right to determine the amount, timing, and eligibility criteria.

Discretionary bonuses are not earned until paid and are not vested in advance. No bonus is guaranteed for any period unless specifically set forth in a separate written agreement signed by both parties.

7. Benefits & Leave Policies

7.1 Benefits Overview

MaximillianGroup is a small, growing firm. Benefit offerings may be limited at this time and are subject to change as the company grows.

Current employees should consult their offer letter and any separately provided benefits documentation for the specific benefits available to them. Nothing in this handbook guarantees any specific level of benefits.

Questions about benefits should be directed to the company principal.

7.2 Paid Sick Leave

In compliance with California's Healthy Workplaces Healthy Families Act, all employees (including part-time and temporary employees) who work in California for at least 30 days in a year are entitled to paid sick leave.

Accrual: Employees accrue paid sick leave at a rate of at least 1 hour per 30 hours worked, or MaximillianGroup may provide a lump-sum amount at the beginning of the year consistent with California law.

Use: Employees may use accrued paid sick leave beginning on the 90th day of employment (or sooner if required by local ordinance). Paid sick leave may be used for:

- The employee's own illness, injury, or preventive care
- Care for a family member (as defined by California law)
- Absences related to domestic violence, sexual assault, or stalking

Carryover and Cap: Unused paid sick leave carries over year to year, subject to applicable caps under California law.

Notice: Employees should provide as much advance notice as possible when taking planned sick leave. For unexpected illness, employees should notify the company principal as soon as practicable.

7.3 Vacation / PTO

MaximillianGroup's vacation and PTO policy is set forth in the employee's offer letter or separate written policy. If MaximillianGroup provides vacation or PTO benefits, the following California rules apply:

No Use-It-or-Lose-It. California law prohibits forfeiture of accrued, unused vacation. Accrued vacation is treated as earned wages and cannot be taken away.

Accrual Cap. MaximillianGroup may impose a reasonable accrual cap, at which point employees temporarily stop accruing additional vacation until they use some of their accrued balance.

Payout at Separation. Accrued, unused vacation must be paid out at the final rate of pay upon separation from employment.

7.4 Holidays

MaximillianGroup observes the following paid holidays, subject to business needs and the terms of the employee's offer letter:

- New Year's Day (January 1)
- Martin Luther King Jr. Day (Third Monday in January)
- Presidents' Day (Third Monday in February)
- Memorial Day (Last Monday in May)
- Juneteenth (June 19)
- Independence Day (July 4)
- Labor Day (First Monday in September)
- Thanksgiving Day (Fourth Thursday in November)
- Day After Thanksgiving
- Christmas Day (December 25)

Holiday schedules may vary and will be communicated in advance. If a holiday falls on a weekend, the observed day will be announced.

7.5 Leaves of Absence

MaximillianGroup complies with all applicable federal and California leave laws. Available leaves of absence depend on the company's current employee count and the specific circumstances. Employees should notify the company principal as early as possible when a leave of absence may be needed.

California Family Rights Act (CFRA)

Eligible employees may take up to 12 weeks of unpaid, job-protected leave per year for qualifying reasons including birth or adoption of a child, care for a seriously ill family member, or the employee's own serious health condition. Eligibility and qualifying reasons are defined by California law. (Applicable to employers with 5+ employees.)

Pregnancy Disability Leave (PDL)

Employees disabled by pregnancy, childbirth, or related medical conditions are entitled to up to 4 months of leave under California's Pregnancy Disability Leave law, regardless of length of service or hours worked. (Applicable to employers with 5+ employees.)

Jury Duty

Employees summoned to jury duty are entitled to take time off to fulfill this obligation. MaximillianGroup will comply with California Labor Code § 230 regarding jury duty leave. Employees should provide advance notice as soon as they receive a summons.

Voting Leave

Employees who do not have sufficient time outside of working hours to vote may take up to 2 hours of paid time off at the beginning or end of their shift to vote, provided they give advance notice. (California Elections Code § 14000.)

Military Leave

MaximillianGroup provides military leave in accordance with the Uniformed Services Employment and Reemployment Rights Act (USERRA) and applicable California law.

Bereavement Leave

Eligible employees are entitled to bereavement leave in accordance with California AB 1949 (5+ employee threshold). Employees may take up to 5 days of bereavement leave upon the death of a qualifying family member. Leave is unpaid for employers with fewer employees than required by law; paid leave may be provided at the company's discretion.

Other Leaves

Additional leaves may be available including, but not limited to: domestic violence/sexual assault leave, school activities leave, victims of crime leave, and reproductive loss leave (for employers with 5+ employees per SB 848). Employees should consult with the company principal about specific circumstances.

7.6 Lactation Accommodation

MaximillianGroup provides reasonable break time and a private, non-bathroom space for employees to express breast milk during the workday, in compliance with California Labor Code §§ 1030–1034.

Employees needing lactation accommodation should notify the company principal in advance. The company will work with the employee to identify an appropriate time and location. Lactation break time will be paid if it coincides with a paid rest break; additional time taken for lactation may be unpaid.

8. Technology, Confidentiality & Intellectual Property

8.1 Confidential Information

“Confidential Information” means all non-public information of MaximillianGroup and its clients, including but not limited to:

- Client identities, strategies, campaigns, marketing plans, and data
- Proprietary methods, processes, and systems
- Financial information, projections, and business plans
- Personnel information
- Vendor and partner relationships and terms
- Proposals, pitches, and creative concepts
- Trade secrets as defined by California law

Employees must protect Confidential Information during and after employment. Confidential Information may not be disclosed to any person outside MaximillianGroup without authorization, and may not be used for any purpose other than performing job duties.

Upon separation from employment, all Confidential Information — including documents, files, and data — must be returned or destroyed per Section 10.3.

8.2 Client Data Protection

MaximillianGroup and its employees are entrusted with client data and have a heightened obligation to protect it.

Minimum Practices:

- Access client data only as necessary for the performance of authorized work
- Store client data only in authorized, company-approved systems
- Do not download or store client data on personal devices without authorization
- Do not share client data with any third party (including subcontractors) without express authorization
- Report any potential data breach, unauthorized access, or mishandling of client data immediately to the company principal

MaximillianGroup complies with the California Consumer Privacy Act (CCPA) and California Privacy Rights Act (CPRA) as applicable. Employees who have questions about data privacy obligations should consult with the company principal.

8.3 Intellectual Property Ownership

This section is critical for an advertising and marketing agency. All employees should read this section carefully.

Work Product Ownership

All work product, creative materials, strategies, deliverables, code, designs, and any other materials created by an employee in the course of employment — whether or not created during regular work hours, on company equipment, or on personal devices — is the sole property of MaximillianGroup (and/or its clients, as applicable per client agreements).

This includes:

- Advertising and marketing campaigns
- Creative assets (copy, design, photography direction, video concepts, brand elements)
- Business development materials, pitch decks, and proposals
- Program designs, frameworks, and methodologies
- Client deliverables of any kind
- AI-generated materials (see Section 8.6)

California Labor Code § 2870 Limitation

Pursuant to California Labor Code § 2870, MaximillianGroup does not claim ownership of inventions that an employee develops entirely on their own time, without use of company equipment, supplies, facilities, or trade secret information — unless the invention relates directly to MaximillianGroup's business or to MaximillianGroup's actual or anticipated research and development, or results from any work performed by the employee for MaximillianGroup.

Assignment of Rights

Employees agree, as a condition of employment, to assign to MaximillianGroup all right, title, and interest in and to all work product covered by this policy. Employees will execute any additional documents necessary to confirm such assignment upon request.

Moral Rights Waiver

To the extent permitted by law, employees waive any moral rights or rights of attribution in work product created in the course of employment.

8.4 Computer, Email & Internet Usage

MaximillianGroup provides and may authorize use of computers, email, internet access, and other technology systems for business purposes. Use of these systems is governed by this policy.

Authorized Use

Technology systems are provided primarily for business use. Limited, incidental personal use that does not interfere with job performance and does not consume significant company resources is generally permitted. However, employees have no right of privacy in their use of company systems, devices, or accounts.

Prohibited Uses

The following uses are strictly prohibited:

- Accessing, transmitting, or storing pornographic, obscene, or offensive material
- Harassment or intimidation through electronic means
- Unauthorized downloading or installation of software
- Circumventing security controls
- Using company systems for personal business, solicitation, or commercial gain without authorization
- Sharing, transmitting, or storing client confidential information in unsecured systems

Monitoring

MaximillianGroup reserves the right to monitor, access, retrieve, and review information stored, transmitted, or received using company-provided systems. Employees have no expectation of privacy in company systems. [If applicable: MaximillianGroup will provide notice of electronic monitoring as required by California law.]

8.5 Social Media Policy

Company Accounts

MaximillianGroup may maintain social media accounts for business purposes. Only authorized employees may post to official MaximillianGroup accounts. All content posted to company accounts must be reviewed and approved in accordance with MaximillianGroup's standard processes.

Personal Accounts

Employees may maintain personal social media accounts, but must:

- Not disclose Confidential Information, including client names and strategies, without authorization
- Not represent personal opinions as official MaximillianGroup positions
- Not post content that constitutes harassment, discrimination, or threats
- Not post content that could damage MaximillianGroup's or a client's reputation without a legitimate protected-activity purpose

California law protects employees' rights to discuss wages, working conditions, and other terms of employment. Nothing in this policy prohibits employees from exercising rights protected by the National Labor Relations Act or California law.

8.6 AI & Generative Tools Policy

MaximillianGroup recognizes that artificial intelligence and generative AI tools (such as ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Midjourney, DALL-E, and similar tools) can be powerful components of creative and business workflows. We are committed to using AI responsibly, ethically, and in compliance with our legal obligations.

Approved Use

AI tools may be used for:

- Research, brainstorming, and ideation
- Draft generation for internal review (with appropriate human oversight and editing)
- Image or visual concept exploration (subject to client and IP restrictions)

- Data analysis and summarization of non-confidential materials

Restrictions and Obligations

Employees using AI tools must comply with the following:

1. **Client Confidentiality:** Do not input client confidential information, proprietary data, strategies, or identifying information into any third-party AI tool without express written authorization. This includes names of clients, campaign details, budgets, and strategic documents.
2. **Approval Before Delivery:** AI-generated content submitted to clients or published publicly must be reviewed, edited, and approved through MaximillianGroup's standard review process before delivery. No AI-generated material should be delivered to a client without human review.
3. **Copyright and Ownership:** The copyright status of AI-generated content is evolving under U.S. and California law. Employees should not assume AI-generated materials are copyright-protected or freely usable without legal analysis. When in doubt, consult the company principal before using AI-generated work in client deliverables.
4. **Accuracy:** AI tools may produce inaccurate, outdated, or misleading information. Employees are responsible for independently verifying facts, claims, and figures before including them in deliverables.
5. **Data Privacy:** Many AI tools store user inputs. Do not input personal information about employees, clients, consumers, or other individuals into AI tools unless the tool has been specifically approved for such use.
6. **Disclosure:** If a client agreement or request requires disclosure of AI use in deliverables, employees must comply with that requirement.

8.7 Recording Meetings & Communications

California is a two-party (all-party) consent state.

Under California Penal Code § 632, recording a confidential communication — including in-person conversations, telephone calls, and video calls — without the consent of all parties is a crime and may subject MaximillianGroup and the employee to significant civil liability.

Requirements:

- Employees must obtain the consent of all parties before recording any call, meeting, or conversation
- This applies to phone calls, video meetings, and in-person conversations
- Many video conferencing platforms display or announce a recording notification — this alone may not be sufficient for California compliance; explicit verbal or written consent from all participants is best practice
- Recordings made with consent must be stored securely and handled in accordance with the confidentiality obligations in this handbook

Do not record conversations involving clients, third parties, or colleagues without prior, unambiguous consent.

9. Safety & Security

9.1 General Safety

MaximillianGroup is committed to providing a safe and healthy work environment for all employees, whether working at a company office, client site, or home office.

Employees are expected to:

- Follow all applicable safety rules and procedures
- Report unsafe conditions, accidents, or near-misses to the company principal promptly
- Use equipment and tools safely and in accordance with manufacturer instructions
- Not engage in conduct that creates unnecessary safety risks for themselves or others

California employers must comply with Cal/OSHA regulations. If MaximillianGroup becomes aware of a Cal/OSHA regulation applicable to our operations, we will implement compliance measures promptly.

9.2 Emergency Procedures

In the event of a workplace emergency:

1. **Immediate Danger:** Call 911 first.
2. **Non-Emergency Safety Concerns:** Report to the company principal.
3. **Natural Disasters:** California's earthquake and wildfire risks mean employees should be prepared with personal emergency plans and should know how to safely evacuate or shelter in place.

Remote employees should familiarize themselves with emergency procedures for their home office location and local area.

9.3 Ergonomics & Remote Work Safety

Employees working remotely are encouraged to set up their workstations ergonomically to reduce the risk of repetitive strain injuries and other work-related musculoskeletal issues.

Basic Ergonomic Recommendations:

- Use a chair with proper lumbar support
- Position the monitor at eye level and at a comfortable distance
- Keep wrists neutral when typing
- Take regular stretch breaks

California employers may be required to provide ergonomic accommodations for employees with documented work-related injuries. Employees experiencing discomfort related to their work setup should notify the company principal.

9.4 Reporting Injuries

Workers' Compensation

MaximillianGroup provides workers' compensation insurance as required by California law. This insurance covers injuries or illnesses arising out of and in the course of employment.

If you are injured at work:

1. Seek necessary medical treatment immediately (call 911 for emergencies)
2. Report the injury to the company principal as soon as possible (within 24 hours when practicable)
3. Complete a workers' compensation claim form (DWC-1), which will be provided by the company

No Retaliation. MaximillianGroup will not retaliate against any employee for filing a legitimate workers' compensation claim.

10. Separation of Employment

10.1 Voluntary Resignation

Employees who wish to resign are encouraged, but not required, to provide advance written notice. While at-will employment means no notice is required, we ask for at least **two weeks' notice** as a professional courtesy to allow for an orderly transition.

Upon receiving notice of resignation, MaximillianGroup may, in its discretion, accelerate the separation date while paying out any remaining scheduled work period.

10.2 Final Pay Rules

California has strict rules regarding final pay timing:

Separation Type	Final Pay Deadline
Involuntary termination (including layoff)	Immediately (same day)
Resignation with 72+ hours' notice	Last day of work
Resignation with less than 72 hours' notice	Within 72 hours of resignation

Final pay must include all earned but unpaid wages, including all accrued, unused vacation (if a vacation policy exists). Failure to timely pay final wages may result in waiting time penalties under California Labor Code § 203 of up to 30 days of wages.

10.3 Return of Company Property

Upon separation, employees must promptly return all company property, including but not limited to:

- Company-owned computers, phones, tablets, or other devices
- Access cards, keys, and badges
- Company credit cards
- Client materials and files (physical and digital)
- Any other property belonging to MaximillianGroup or its clients

Unreturned company property may be subject to recovery through appropriate legal means. MaximillianGroup will not deduct the value of unreturned property from final wages without a written authorization signed by the employee (and only if such deduction would not reduce wages below minimum wage), except as permitted by California law.

10.4 Exit Procedures

At or before the last day of employment, the company principal will conduct or arrange:

- Revocation of access credentials (email, internal systems, client platforms)
- Transfer or transition of ongoing work responsibilities
- Completion of any required exit documentation
- Review of continuing obligations (see Section 10.5)

Former employees may request their personnel file in accordance with California Labor Code § 1198.5.

10.5 Continuing Confidentiality Obligations

The obligation to protect MaximillianGroup's and clients' Confidential Information survives the end of employment. Former employees may not:

- Use or disclose Confidential Information for any purpose after separation
- Retain copies of client files, strategies, or proprietary materials
- Contact MaximillianGroup's clients in ways that breach any applicable non-solicitation provision

Former employees will be reminded of these obligations in the exit process and may be asked to sign an acknowledgment.

Note: California law generally does not enforce post-employment non-compete agreements. MaximillianGroup does not require employees to sign non-compete agreements, and any such provision will be construed consistent with California Business and Professions Code § 16600. Non-solicitation provisions remain subject to ongoing legal review.

11. Required California Policies & Notices

Paid Sick Leave Notice

MaximillianGroup provides paid sick leave to all eligible employees as required by the Healthy Workplaces Healthy Families Act (California Labor Code §§ 245–249). Employees who believe they have not received their entitled paid sick leave should contact the company principal or the California Labor Commissioner's Office.

Harassment Policy (Summary)

MaximillianGroup prohibits harassment based on any protected characteristic. See Section 4.2 for the full policy. Complaints may be directed to the company principal or to the California Civil Rights Department (CRD) at 1-800-884-1684.

Victims of Crime Leave

California Labor Code § 230.1 requires employers with 25 or more employees to provide leave for victims of domestic violence, sexual assault, or stalking to seek relief, medical attention, or safety planning. MaximillianGroup provides this leave to the extent required by law and, to the extent legally permissible, on a voluntary basis regardless of employee count.

Whistleblower Protections

California Labor Code § 1102.5 prohibits employers from retaliating against employees who disclose information they reasonably believe constitutes a violation of law. MaximillianGroup will not retaliate against any employee for making a good-faith complaint to a government agency, law enforcement, or to MaximillianGroup itself. The State of California maintains a whistleblower hotline at 1-800-952-5225.

Paid Family Leave (PFL)

California's Paid Family Leave program is administered by the State of California through the Employment Development Department (EDD). Eligible employees may receive partial wage replacement benefits through the state program for qualifying family care leaves. This is a state program, not a MaximillianGroup benefit. For information, visit https://www.edd.ca.gov/disability/paid_family_leave.htm.

Workers' Compensation Notice

MaximillianGroup provides workers' compensation insurance as required by California law. If you are injured on the job, notify the company principal immediately. You have the right to seek medical treatment and to file a claim for workers' compensation benefits.

OSHA / Cal/OSHA Notice

Employees have rights under California Occupational Safety and Health regulations (Cal/OSHA). Information about Cal/OSHA is available at <https://www.dir.ca.gov/dosh/>. Employees have the right to report workplace hazards to Cal/OSHA without retaliation.

Reproductive Loss Leave

California SB 848 (effective January 1, 2024) requires employers with 5 or more employees to provide up to 5 days of unpaid leave following a reproductive loss event (including miscarriage, failed surrogacy, and related events). MaximillianGroup complies with this law as applicable and will implement it voluntarily regardless of employee count.

Electronic Monitoring Disclosures

If MaximillianGroup monitors or intercepts employee electronic communications or computer usage, employees will be notified as required by California Penal Code § 630.8 and applicable law. See also Section 8.4 (Computer, Email & Internet Usage).

CCPA / Privacy Disclosures

Employees who are California residents have rights under the California Consumer Privacy Act (CCPA) and California Privacy Rights Act (CPRA) regarding the collection, use, and sharing of their personal information.

MaximillianGroup will provide separate privacy notices to employees as required by applicable law.

12. Forms & Acknowledgments

The following forms are part of this handbook and may be provided digitally or in paper form:

Form 1: Employee Acknowledgment

I, _____, acknowledge that I have received, read, and understood the Maximillian-Group Employee Handbook, effective _____.

I understand that: - This handbook is not a contract of employment - Employment at MaximillianGroup is at-will - MaximillianGroup may modify this handbook at any time - I am responsible for knowing and following the policies in this handbook

Employee Signature: _____

Date: _____

Form 2: Confidentiality Agreement Acknowledgment

I acknowledge that I have received and reviewed the Confidentiality and Intellectual Property Agreement and understand my obligations to protect MaximillianGroup's and its clients' confidential information during and after my employment.

Employee Signature: _____

Date: _____

Form 3: Equipment Receipt

I acknowledge receipt of the following company equipment, which remains the property of Maximillian-Group and must be returned upon separation:

Item	Serial / ID	Condition
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Employee Signature: _____

Date: _____

Form 4: Remote Work Agreement

I acknowledge that I have been authorized to work remotely, and I agree to comply with MaximillianGroup's Remote Work Policy (Section 5.6), including the requirements regarding confidentiality, equipment security, and professional conduct.

Work Location: _____

Employee Signature: _____

Date: _____

Form 5: Expense Reimbursement Request

Employee: _____

Date Submitted: _____

Pay Period / Month: _____

Date	Description	Category	Amount	Receipt Attached?	
			\$	Yes	No
			\$	Yes	No
			\$	Yes	No
Total			\$		

I certify that all expenses listed above were incurred for legitimate business purposes.

Employee Signature: _____

Date: _____

Approved by: _____

Date: _____

Form 6: Timekeeping Acknowledgment

I acknowledge that I am a non-exempt employee and that I am responsible for accurately recording all hours worked, including start and end times and all meal and rest break periods. I understand that falsification of time records may result in disciplinary action, up to and including termination.

Employee Signature: _____

Date: _____

Form 7: Employee Complaint Form

Employee Name: _____

Date: _____

Nature of Complaint: Harassment Discrimination Wage/Hour Safety Other: _____

Description of the complaint *(include dates, names of involved parties, and any witnesses):*

Relief or resolution requested (optional):

Have you previously reported this matter? Yes No

If yes, to whom and when: _____

Employee Signature: _____

Date: _____

Form 8: PTO / Vacation Request

Employee Name: _____

Date of Request: _____

Requested Leave Dates: _____ to _____

Number of Days: _____

Type of Leave: Vacation / PTO Paid Sick Leave Other: _____

Reason (optional): _____

Employee Signature: _____

Date: _____

Approved / Denied by: _____

Date: _____

End of MaximillianGroup Employee Handbook

Important Disclaimer: This handbook is provided for informational purposes and reflects MaximillianGroup's general policies. It is not legal advice. California employment laws are complex and change frequently. MaximillianGroup recommends that this handbook and all employment agreements, contractor agreements, and related policies be reviewed by a qualified California employment attorney before implementation or distribution to employees.

MaximillianGroup | Pasadena, California